

spread evenly over a month. Sailesh Peringatt, a programmer, prefers to freelance for the interest quotient. It allows him to pick and choose interesting jobs. "This way, you tend to learn and grow very fast in terms of knowledge as you are not limiting yourself," says Peringatt.

Such a work scenario may mean professional schizophrenia—where you are a copywriter in the morning, a technical writer in the afternoon and editor in the evening—but it assures intellectual stimulation. For Naik, it means working on a large spectrum of magazines. Diwali usually means working on special editions of Marathi magazines, while year-ends see him working on IT publications. Each magazine has its own style and focus and this diversity is what keeps Naik intrigued.

Since working on your own takes away one very big advantage that a corporate house offers—that of frequent training sessions that keep one abreast of the latest trends, freelancers have to rely



Amith Ellur
MICROSOFT CONSULTANT

The advantage for me over an employed individual is that I can play different roles at all possible levels

upon themselves to update their skills and knowledge. "Most of my free time is spent learning new languages and processes so as to handle any kind of project," says Peringatt. Ellur agrees: "Freelancers are entrepreneurs by themselves, so they have to keep learning and updating their knowledge to provide quality solutions on time, every time."

Another thing an independent worker can't fall back on is a support system. Corporate clients have well-drawn legal con-

tracts that can be quite daunting to a newbie. While such paperwork assures that the freelancer isn't exploited, it can also be used against the individual worker in case the work is not delivered on time or isn't up to a certain quality. "Corporates are well-equipped to handle freelancers who don't deliver quality. A freelancer is most of the times a one-man show with no legal assistance, whereas corporates have access to virtually everything. So if a freelancer doesn't deliver quality, the client can stop payments and also get legal clauses in the way. Not to mention, that they can give you a poor recommendation, which will hinder your future projects," explains Ellur.

Independent working doesn't necessarily translate to working from home. Just like in a 9-5 job, the client is the king and your work habits rotate around him. The type of project you are working on decides your location of work. "Most of the times clients don't want the project details to go out of the office boundary,

The Website Story

'Now you can work on your own terms'... or so they say

The Internet is brim full of Web sites that claim to offer big money with minimum work hours. But like everything else on the Net, many of them are just database mining sites that require you to sign up for a fee or pay for the training pack. The exact nature of the work is ambiguous. But some offer genuine solutions for those sitting at home.

Some Web sites offer data processing jobs such as converting books or PDF formats into online documents and other text conversion jobs. Other jobs include medical transcription, which involves receiving dictations of medical notes and then transcribing that data into a digital format and rerouting it to the respective doctor. These jobs require you to have some kind of scientific or medical background to aid your understanding of the scientific terms. Other work opportunities include basic data entry, replying to e-mail, receiving mail responses, pursuing helpdesk on mail and chat. This is quite on the lines of a Call Centre.

Some sites offer to pay for just click-

ing on advertisements to assure advertisers of user response. Given below are some sites that let you work from home:

Elance.com (www.elance.com) is a work-from-home site. As cited by one end user, for a particular project you might have to pay Rs 6,000 towards registration, but at the end of it you could earn up to Rs 15,000. Even though you have to pay a certain sum at the commencement of a project, this amount is usually recovered by the end of the project.

Guru.com (www.guru.com) gauges your potential and directs you to the right job.



Elance.com is one of the popular choices of freelancers



Guru.com has a team of experts that evaluates your potential

The mode of payment can be chosen between a monthly salary and an hourly rate. They have a 'Workstyle at a glance' section, which is designed to help the user and the staff learn more about the preferred work environment. Once your skills are assessed and you've entered the cycle, it is fairly easy to find the right kind of work. Make sure to read the clauses associated with each type of job.

Datamatics.com (www.datamatics.com) is one of the pioneering work-at-home sites in India. However, a previous user